NewsBank inc.

STATE ASSEMBLY - New speaker's arc: Poverty to power

June 27, 2023 | Marin Independent Journal (San Rafael, CA)
Author: By Lindsey Holden, Mathew Miranda, Stephen Hobbs The Sacramento Bee | Section: News | 1362 Words
Page: 1
OpenURL Link

Robert Rivas tells anyone who will listen that his rise from farmworker housing on the rural Central Coast to Assembly speaker is wholly unexpected, the California Dream become reality.

The Hollister Assemblyman, who assumes the role on Friday, presents himself as a humble, soft-spoken person who fell into the job.

But many who have watched his climb from an outgoing high-schooler to a San Benito County supervisor to one of the most powerful political offices in the state are not surprised.

Throughout his journey, Rivas, 43, has carefully balanced policy and pragmatism. He made an early name for himself as an anti-fracking environmental champion, but he's also proved he can collaborate with more conservative colleagues.

And even in a Capitol filled with strivers seeking more powerful roles, Rivas' ambition stands out. At least six months before making his move against current Speaker Anthony Rendon, D-Lakewood, Ri

vas and his political consultant brother were already starting to plot his power play.

"My impression is Rob knows he can do good things in politics and is not going to waste that opportunity," said Wayne Norton, a member of the San Benito County Democratic Central Committee and a longtime Rivas ally.

Rivas spent much of his childhood in Paicines, an unincorporated San Benito County community about 55 miles southeast of San Jose.

He was an infant when his mother, Mayra Flores, brought him from Henderson, Nevada, to live with her parents. As a single mom, she worked as a school secretary and kindergarten teacher while raising him and younger brother Rick.

Their grandfather, Servando Flores, was a Mexican immigrant who found long-term work at Almaden Vineyards. Rivas spent his first few years in grower-provided farmworker housing — a three-bedroom, 600-square-foot duplex he shared with nine relatives, according to Rivas' aunt, Nidya Norma Flores Fidler.

The legacy of the United Farm Workers labor union looms large in Rivas' family history. Servando organized for the UFW alongside civil rights icon Dolores Huerta. One of his paychecks hangs on a wall in Rivas' Assembly office.

"I didn't know we lived in poverty," Rivas said. "I spent all my time outside riding my bike. I spent a lot of time with my brother climbing trees — we had these huge fig trees."

Rivas attended San Benito High School — now Hollister High School — and then enrolled at Butte College in Oroville. Cuco Chavez, who roomed with him, said his friend began devoting long hours to reading and writing papers. He dug into books on Andrew Jackson and Abraham Lincoln and had a poster of John F. Kennedy in his room.

No political origin story about Rivas is complete without his brother Rick, his "closest adviser," as he frequently calls him.

Robert leaves no doubt about Rick's importance. Together they forged a partnership that continues to this day.

"He's a political genius," he said. "I wouldn't be here without him."

Although Robert ended up as the elected official, some say Rick is the savvier of the two.

The brothers "grew up almost as twins but have totally different personalities," said Sen. Anna Caballero, D-Merced. Rick and Robert worked on her successful 2006 Assembly campaign.

"(Rick) understands politics in a way that Robert is not interested in," she added. "Robert is talented in policy and making friends and being a good colleague, and Rick just has different skills."

Rick remains heavily involved in his brother's life and career — the two live together with a cousin when they're in Sacramento. Their close relationship has raised concerns because of Rick's deep ties to Sacramento politics.

Rick is California vice president for the American Beverage Association, a trade group for PepsiCo, the Coca-Cola Co. and other makers of non-alcoholic drinks. He leads the group's government and public affairs work in the state, but is not a registered lobbyist.

Rick has also worked as a legislative affairs director for Govern for California, an organization that wants to push back on the influence of "government employee unions, healthcare providers, crony capitalists, regulated entities, and rent seekers."

Despite his lobbying and advocacy background, Rick's work does not appear to have influenced Robert's voting record.

Rick declined repeated interview requests, but he was involved in fielding Bee inquiries for other family members.

Robert said his brother is not on his payroll. And supporters of the two insist their closeness is not a problem.

According to California law, public officials aren't supposed to use their positions to make or influence governmental decisions to benefit themselves or family members. But the law only considers spouses, registered domestic partners and dependent children as family members.

"You can't fault somebody for having family in the business," said Assemblyman Devon Mathis, R-Porterville, who serves on the Assembly Agriculture Committee with Rivas. "But it does draw the question: How much of an influence is that?"

Rivas' early political career included stints as a field representative for former Assemblyman Simon Salinas and a campaign staffer for Caballero. Publicly, however, Robert Rivas has long stated he never thought he could be a politician.

But his mentors saw more potential.

Caballero and Salinas encouraged him to run for the San Benito County Board of Supervisors in 2010. He won, and at 31 was younger and more liberal than other supervisors. Former conservative Supervisor Anthony Botelho said he initially felt Rivas was still in campaign mode, criticizing other board members rather than trying to find consensus.

After Rivas' first year in office, Botelho sat down with him and suggested a different approach.

"You have to reach out and see where people are, rather than be critical behind the scenes," Botelho recalled telling him. He said Rivas followed his advice.

Rivas said his experience in local politics taught him important lessons about relationships and working with people who have different ideologies.

“You have to find a way, whether you’re Republican, Democrat, whether your values align or not,” he said.

Fracking and the environment became early priorities as a supervisor. Norton and anti-fracking activists started meeting with him around 2012 as they began efforts to more heavily regulate county oil and gas drillers.

“We didn’t have to convince him,” Norton said. “He knew what we were talking about. He knew the issue, and he knew how important it was.”

In 2014, Rivas supported a successful local ballot measure to ban fracking in certain parts of the county. The issue helped raise his profile and played a role in propelling him toward the Assembly.

Rivas claims he “didn’t come to the building wanting to be speaker.” But within three years, he coveted the role.

Behind the governor, the Assembly speaker is one of the most powerful political figures in the state. The speaker oversees California’s largest political body, which means selecting committee assignments, controlling the flow of legislation and negotiating the budget. He also influences a multimillon-dollar campaign fund for Assembly candidates.

In December 2021 Rick told Norton his brother might make a play for the job. At that time, Rivas was chair of the Assembly Agriculture Committee and vice chair of the California Latino Legislative Caucus.

He eventually approached colleagues about endorsing him for the position.

By late May 2022, Rivas had built enough support to officially challenge Rendon. Multiple members who backed Rivas said in interviews they found his childhood story — the years spent in farmworker housing, overcoming a stutter — compelling and part of the reason he would make a good speaker.

“It’s the kind of story that makes you feel good about California and good about the California Dream,” said Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-San Fernando Valley.

But Rendon wasn’t prepared to simply give up the speakership. He held onto the job after a bruising six-hour Democratic caucus meeting.

The battle continued through the summer and into Assembly midterm elections. Rivas supporters gave money to a political action committee that had the goal of making him the next speaker, instead of using the more traditional Democratic Party funding operation.

Following the election, an emotional Rivas and a group of jubilant Assembly members emerged from another lengthy caucus meeting and announced a deal that would result in a transfer of power on June 30.

He took the moment to tell his story once again.

“Only in California can we say that a kid that came from farmworker housing ascended to be the next speaker of the California state Assembly.”

Distributed by Tribune News Service

(c) 2023 Marin Independent Journal. All rights reserved. Reproduced with the permission of Media NewsGroup, Inc. by NewsBank, Inc.

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Lindsey Holden, B. (2023, June 27). STATE ASSEMBLY New speaker’s arc: Poverty to power*Marin Independent Journal (San Rafael,*

CA), p. 1. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1926ADF39B197830.